# PRIMUS · Sector Case Book

Five sectors for the three rounds and three tracks: FMCG, Energy, Aviation, Fintech and Luxury

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## 1 · How PRIMUS works

| Part | What happens |
|---|---|
| **Three tracks** | Product teams build a startup and run it as a listed company. Consulting teams are firms that companies hire for advice. Finance teams are funds that invest in the companies and trade their shares. |
| **Round 1 · Foundation** | Product teams write a PRD (product requirements document) for a startup inside their sector's problem statement; its AI-judged score sets the company's IPO price. Consulting firms write a crisis memo on one case that is the same for every firm; its score builds their reputation. Funds read the PRDs, ask questions, bid in the IPO and make their first trades. |
| **Round 2 · Pressure (four crises)** | Four crisis cards arrive one after another. Each reveal knocks 5% off every price. Product teams hire a consulting firm and write a response plan; the hired firm writes an advice memo; plans are judged and their scores move prices; companies rate their firm. Funds trade on every card and every score. |
| **Round 3 · Saturation** | Problem statements narrower than the sector brief are drafted, lowest score first. Companies on the same statement compete for the price rise. Each writes a solution with a hired firm. Funds receive fresh capital and finish with the highest return they can. |

## 2 · How the sector packs plug in

- Each sector's broad problem statement becomes a problem card (the platform's problem cards carry a sector). Every Product team invents its own startup inside it.
- Crisis cards are written so that any startup in the sector can face them. Real companies appear only as inspiration.
- Each Round 2 crisis has one type: OPERATIONS, MARKET, TRUST or MONEY. Using one of each across the four crises tests a different skill every time.

- Every card carries numbers (a percentage lost, a cost in rupees, a time) so funds can price it and the judge can check plans against it.
- Spare cards are listed for each sector: use them to replace a card, for a rehearsal, or as a mid-round surprise announced in a bulletin.
- Round 3 statements take at most 5 companies each; ten statements give room for all 50 companies.

Each sector below has the same parts: an overview, the problem statement, opportunity areas, real-world challenges, startups for inspiration, an illustrative concept, what a strong PRD shows, the consulting memo case, four crisis cards with a hint of a strong response, spare cards, ten Round 3 statements and what funds should watch.

> **Fairness.** All numbers on the cards are invented for the game and are the same for every company that receives the card. Real startups are named for inspiration only; teams must not copy them, and the judge scores the team's own plan.

# 3 · Sector ranking

| Sector | Fit | Why |
|---|---|---|
| **FMCG** | Excellent | The most relatable sector: every student buys these products, so plans are concrete and crises are easy to picture. |
| **Energy** | Excellent | Policy, prices and outages make big, clear price moves that funds can trade on. |
| **Aviation** | Very good | The brief asks for an MVP anywhere in the value chain (not an airline), so student startups stay realistic. |
| **Fintech** | Very good | Broad enough for every team to find a startup; regulation and trust make sharp crises. Quant trading is one option inside it. |
| **Luxury** | Good with this brief | The opportunity areas and crisis scenarios make it workable; numbers are harder to pin down, so the cards give them explicitly. |

# 4 · FMCG: Fast-moving consumer goods

FMCG covers the everyday products people buy again and again: food, drinks, personal care and household goods. The sector runs on thin margins, huge volumes and long distribution chains that reach millions of small shops. That makes every problem, from spoilt stock to a viral complaint, show up quickly in sales and margins, which is exactly what the game needs.

## Broad problem statement (Round 1 · the problem card)

> The FMCG industry is undergoing a significant transformation as consumers increasingly demand healthier products, greater transparency, sustainability, personalized experiences, and seamless product availability. However, many companies continue to struggle with understanding rapidly changing consumer preferences, optimizing supply chains, reducing product wastage, ensuring efficient last-mile distribution, and building trust through authentic and transparent practices. Design an innovative startup that addresses one or more of these interconnected challenges to help FMCG businesses become more consumer-centric, operationally efficient, sustainable, and future-ready.

## Opportunity areas

### Demand and retail intelligence

- Forecasting for festivals, seasons and local tastes
- Inventory tools for small retailers and distributors
- Shelf and price analytics for modern trade and quick commerce

### Supply chain and last mile

- Cold chain for fresh and frozen food
- Route and fleet optimisation
- Reaching rural shops profitably

### Healthier and honest products

- Better-for-you food at mass prices
- Clear labels and ingredient traceability
- Personalised nutrition

### Sustainability

- Plastic-free and refill packaging
- Food-waste reduction and recovery
- Traceable, ethical sourcing

## Real-world industry challenges

| Challenge | Why it matters |
|---|---|
| **Fast-changing tastes** | Preferences shift by city, season and social media trend faster than plants and supply chains can follow. |
| **Waste and spoilage** | Perishable stock is lost at every step from farm to shelf, eating into thin margins. |
| **The last mile** | Millions of small shops order little and often; serving them profitably is hard. |
| **Trust** | Consumers doubt health and sustainability claims, and one viral post can undo years of branding. |
| **Channel dependence** | Quick-commerce apps and big retailers control shelf space, data and pricing power. |

## Startups for inspiration

- **Bizom (India)**: Retail intelligence, inventory optimisation and demand forecasting for fragmented distribution.
- **Locus (India)**: AI logistics and last-mile route optimisation.
- **RELEX Solutions**: Demand forecasting and inventory optimisation across online and offline channels.
- **Licious (India)**: Fresh food supply chain sold direct to consumers.
- **Provenance**: Product traceability and sustainability verification.
- **Crisp**: Retail analytics and consumer insights.

## Illustrative startup concept

**FRESHLOOP.** A demand-sensing and redistribution platform for perishable FMCG. It forecasts each shop's sales by day, moves near-expiry stock to shops or channels that will sell it, and donates or recycles what is left.

**Revenue:** Software subscription from brands and distributors; A share of the waste saved; Data products for retail chains.

## Product track · what a strong PRD shows

- A specific user (a brand, a distributor, a shop owner or a shopper) and the pain in numbers
- A first version small enough to launch in one city or one category
- Unit economics: cost and margin per unit, order or shop
- How it reaches shops or shoppers, and who pays
- Success metrics such as waste %, fill rate, repeat purchase or margin

## Consulting track · Round 1 crisis memo (same case for every firm)

**Festival forecast failure.** A mid-size snacks brand used an AI forecast for Diwali. It over-stocked sweets by 40% in metros and ran out of savoury packs in tier-2 towns. Rs 3.2 crore of sweets expire in 6 weeks and retailers are angry.

Recommend one way out, with numbers: discount and donate, divert stock to other channels, or rebuild the forecast with retailer data. A strong memo chooses one, costs it, and says how to stop it happening next festival.

## Round 2 · crisis cards

| Type | Card | What happens | A strong response |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 · OPERATIONS | **Heatwave breaks the cold chain** | A 46°C heatwave hits North India. Your cold chain fails in 3 cities: 18% of this week's stock spoils and 2,400 customers post complaints. Refunds cost Rs 41 lakh. | Protect the remaining stock first, then customers: who gets refunds, how fast, and what changes in storage and routes. Price the fix against the loss. |
| 2 · MARKET | **A giant gives it away free** | A quick-commerce giant launches a free version of your core product or service for its partners. 22% of your customers say they will switch within a month. | Find what the free version cannot do, defend the customers who value it, and decide whether to partner, niche down or compete on price, with the cost of each. |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **3 · TRUST** | **Fake sustainability data** | A journalist shows that a key supplier faked its 'plastic-free' and 'organic' data, which you printed on your packs. #Greenwashing trends with your name in it. | Own it quickly, pull or relabel what is wrong, verify suppliers independently and show proof. Estimate the cost and the sales at risk. |
| **4 · MONEY** | **Raw materials up 30%** | Palm oil, packaging and fuel costs rise 30% in a quarter. Your gross margin falls from 34% to 21%, and your next funding round is now in doubt. | Choose between price rises, smaller packs, cheaper inputs and cost cuts, and show the cash runway under the chosen plan. |

**Spare cards (replacements, rehearsals or a mid-round surprise)**

- A quick-commerce app changes its ranking algorithm: your products drop off the first screen and sales fall 28%
- A product recall: one batch fails a food-safety test in 2 states
- A cyberattack locks your ordering system for 3 days during peak season
- Privacy rules stop you using purchase data for personalisation
- Your largest enterprise client (34% of revenue) does not renew

## Round 3 · problem statements (at most 5 companies each)

1. Cut fresh-food waste from 9% to 3% across the supply chain
2. Reach 50,000 rural kirana shops profitably
3. Plastic-free packaging that costs under Rs 1 more per pack
4. Honest health labels shoppers actually read
5. Forecast festival demand within 10% across city types
6. Win shelf space on quick-commerce apps against big brands
7. Make healthy snacks affordable under Rs 20
8. Trace every ingredient from farm to pack in seconds
9. Return and refill systems for household products
10. Personalised nutrition for India's diabetic population

## Finance track · what funds should watch

| Signal | Why |
|---|---|
| **Margin per unit** | Does the plan protect it after a cost shock? |
| **Wastage %** | A falling number is a strong buy signal. |
| **Acquisition cost vs repeat rate** | Repeat buyers make FMCG profitable. |
| **Channel dependence** | One app or retailer holding most sales is a risk. |
| **Cash runway** | Months of cash left at the current burn. |

# 5 · ENERGY: Clean energy and power

India must add a great deal of power capacity this decade while cutting emissions. Rooftop solar, EV charging, batteries and smart grids are growing fast, but they depend on subsidies, imported hardware and a grid that struggles at peak times. Policy changes and price swings hit these businesses hard and visibly, which gives funds clear signals to trade on.

## Broad problem statement (Round 1 · the problem card)

> The energy transition is reshaping how power is produced, stored, distributed and used. Rooftop solar, electric mobility, batteries and smart grids are growing fast, yet customers find clean energy costly and confusing, grids struggle with peak demand and outages, hardware supply chains are fragile, and businesses cannot measure or reduce their emissions with confidence. Design an innovative startup that makes clean energy cheaper, more reliable, easier to adopt or easier to measure, for homes, businesses, farms or cities, while remaining commercially viable without permanent subsidies.

## Opportunity areas

### Generation and storage

- Rooftop and community solar
- Batteries suited to Indian heat
- Storage for farms and cold chains

### Electric mobility

- Charging networks for cities and highways
- Battery swapping for two- and three-wheelers
- Fleet electrification for delivery companies

### Grid and demand

- Peak-demand reduction and smart tariffs
- Paying consumers to save or shift power
- Microgrids for villages and campuses

### Carbon and circularity

- Carbon accounting for small factories
- Recycling batteries and panels
- Green power for data centres and industry

## Real-world industry challenges

| Challenge | Why it matters |
|---|---|
| **Upfront cost** | Clean energy saves money over years but costs a lot on day one. |
| **Subsidy dependence** | Many business cases work only while subsidies last. |
| **Hardware supply** | Panels, cells and chips are largely imported and swing in price. |
| **Reliability** | Heat, dust and grid outages shorten equipment life and break promises to customers. |
| **Safety and trust** | Battery fires and installer quality problems make customers wary. |

## Startups for inspiration

- **SolarSquare (India)**: Rooftop solar for homes on easy monthly payments.
- **Statiq (India)**: EV charging network for cities and highways.
- **Log9 Materials (India)**: Fast-charging batteries for Indian conditions.
- **Octopus Energy (UK)**: Software-led energy retail with smart tariffs.
- **Sinai Technologies**: Carbon accounting for industry.

## Illustrative startup concept

**SUNSHARE.** Community solar for apartment blocks and renters. Residents buy shares of a shared rooftop or nearby plant through an app and see the savings on their power bill.
**Revenue:** A margin on each share sold; A monthly service fee; Selling surplus power to the grid.

## Product track · what a strong PRD shows

- Who adopts it and what they pay today for power, fuel or carbon
- The payback period with and without subsidies
- How the hardware is sourced, installed and maintained
- Safety and reliability in Indian conditions
- Success metrics such as cost per unit of power, uptime or tonnes of carbon saved

## Consulting track · Round 1 crisis memo (same case for every firm)

**Solar subsidy cut.** A rooftop solar installer sells 1,200 systems a month, 70% of them with a Rs 30,000 government subsidy. The state cuts the subsidy to Rs 10,000 from next month. Orders already booked fall by 35% in a week.
Recommend one way out, with numbers: lower prices, add financing, shift to businesses, or bundle batteries. A strong memo shows the new payback period customers will see.

## Round 2 · crisis cards

| Type | Card | What happens | A strong response |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 · OPERATIONS | **Grid blackout in peak summer** | A 9-hour blackout across 4 states. Your systems or stations go offline, 30% of customers miss service, and penalty clauses cost Rs 55 lakh. | Restore service in order of customer impact, communicate clearly, and design backup or islanding so the next blackout hurts less. Cost it. |
| 2 · MARKET | **Cheap imports flood the market** | Solar panels and batteries from abroad drop 25% in price. Your hardware now costs more than rivals' and two big orders are cancelled. | Compete where imports are weak (service, warranty, financing, installation quality) or change suppliers; show the new margin. |
| 3 · TRUST | **A battery fire goes viral** | A video of a battery fire at a customer site gets 4 million views. The fire was not proven to be yours, but bookings fall 40% and a regulator asks for safety data. | Be transparent, cooperate with the regulator, publish safety evidence and offer free inspections. Estimate the cost of rebuilding bookings. |
| 4 · MONEY | **Subsidy cut overnight** | The government cuts the subsidy your customers rely on from Rs 30,000 to Rs 10,000. Your payback pitch of 4 years becomes 6.5 years. | Rebuild the offer without the subsidy: financing, smaller systems or a new segment, and show the runway. |

### Spare cards (replacements, rehearsals or a mid-round surprise)

- A lithium price spike raises battery costs 40%
- A new rule requires local manufacturing for subsidy eligibility

- A cyberattack takes over smart meters in one city
- Your main installer partner goes bankrupt
- A heatwave cuts panel output 15% for a month

## Round 3 · problem statements (at most 5 companies each)

1. Rooftop solar for renters and apartment blocks
2. EV charging on highways that pays for itself in 3 years
3. Batteries that survive Indian summers for 10 years
4. Carbon tracking a small factory can afford
5. Cutting peak-hour demand without blackouts
6. Clean cooking for 20 crore rural homes
7. Recycling used EV and solar batteries
8. Green power for cold storage on farms
9. Paying households for power they save
10. Clean energy for 24/7 data centres

## Finance track · what funds should watch

| Signal | Why |
|---|---|
| **Subsidy dependence** | How much of the business case survives a policy change. |
| **Payback period** | What customers are promised, and whether it holds. |
| **Hardware cost vs imports** | Exposure to global price swings. |
| **Safety record** | One incident can stop sales. |
| **Debt and runway** | Energy projects borrow heavily. |

# 6 · AVIATION: Reimagining the future of aviation

Aviation is far more than airlines: airports, ground handling, maintenance, cargo, drones, air taxis and the passenger journey from door to door. Airlines need huge capital, so this brief asks teams for an MVP anywhere in that wider value chain. Fuel prices, safety incidents and regulators move these businesses sharply, which suits the game.

## Broad problem statement (Round 1 · the problem card)

The global aviation industry is undergoing a fundamental transformation, with rising operational complexities, evolving passenger expectations, infrastructure constraints and growing sustainability concerns challenging traditional business models. From inefficiencies across airport operations and fragmented passenger experiences to gaps in accessibility, resource utilisation and emerging aviation services, the industry presents significant opportunities for innovation. Your challenge: identify an untapped opportunity or an existing inefficiency within the aviation ecosystem and develop an innovative product, service or business solution that redefines how the industry operates, serves its customers or creates value. Your solution may address any part of the aviation value chain, including passenger experience, airport infrastructure, airline operations, logistics, sustainability, aviation technology or emerging mobility models. Think beyond conventional aviation solutions. Objective: build an MVP that addresses a meaningful industry gap while demonstrating a clear value proposition, target market and potential for real-world adoption. How might we leverage disruptive innovation, emerging business models and unconventional solutions to redefine aviation, unlock untapped market opportunities and engineer the next generation of air travel?

## Opportunity areas

### Passenger experience

- Faster security, check-in and boarding
- Accessibility for passengers with disabilities
- One journey from door to door

### Airport and airline operations

- Faster aircraft turnaround
- Baggage tracking and recovery
- Crew and gate planning

### Logistics and new mobility

- Drone delivery of medicines and parcels
- Regional and short-hop flights
- Electric air taxis

### Sustainability and technology

- Fuel and carbon optimisation
- Sustainable aviation fuel
- Predictive maintenance

## Real-world industry challenges

| Challenge | Why it matters |
|---|---|
| **Congestion** | Airports grow slower than passenger numbers, so queues and delays rise. |
| **Thin margins** | Airlines earn little per seat and are very sensitive to fuel prices. |
| **Fragmented journeys** | Booking, airport, airline and onward travel rarely talk to each other. |
| **Regulation and safety** | Every new service needs approvals, and one incident can ground it. |
| **Sustainability pressure** | Flying is hard to decarbonise and scrutiny is growing. |

## Startups for inspiration

- **DigiYatra (India)**: Face-based, paperless passenger entry at airports.
- **Skye Air (India)**: Drone delivery networks for parcels and medicines.
- **The ePlane Company (India)**: Electric air taxis for short city hops.
- **Assaia**: AI that watches aircraft turnarounds to cut delays.
- **SITA**: Shared IT for airports and airlines: bags, check-in, data.
- **Joby Aviation**: Electric vertical take-off aircraft for urban air mobility.

## Illustrative startup concept

**TURNWISE.** Computer vision at the gate that tracks every step of an aircraft turnaround (fuelling, catering, baggage, cleaning) and warns the ground team before a delay happens.
**Revenue:** A subscription per gate for airports; A per-flight fee for airlines; Delay-analytics reports for ground handlers.

## Product track · what a strong PRD shows

- Which part of the value chain, which customer (airport, airline, passenger, shipper) and the pain in minutes, rupees or passengers
- An MVP that can be tested at one airport, route or fleet
- Approvals needed and how long they take
- Safety, reliability and data privacy
- Success metrics such as minutes saved, on-time %, cost per flight or passengers served

## Consulting track · Round 1 crisis memo (same case for every firm)

**Monsoon delay meltdown.** A regional airline flies 60 daily flights from 3 airports. In one monsoon week, poor turnaround planning causes 38% of flights to leave late, 9 cancellations and 4,200 stranded passengers. Compensation and rebooking cost Rs 2.6 crore and its on-time rank falls to last.
Recommend one way out, with numbers: buffer the schedule, invest in turnaround software, cut routes, or a passenger recovery programme. A strong memo weighs the cost against the delays it removes.

## Round 2 · crisis cards

| Type | Card | What happens | A strong response |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 · OPERATIONS | **Airport IT outage** | A software failure takes check-in, boarding passes and baggage systems down at 3 major airports for 9 hours. 31,000 passengers are affected and your product or service stops working with them. | Keep customers moving with a manual fallback, communicate, and build redundancy. Estimate the cost of downtime and of the fix. |
| 2 · MARKET | **A giant builds its own** | The country's largest airline launches its own free version of your product for its passengers and partners. 30% of your users say they will switch within a quarter. | Serve the customers the giant ignores (other airlines, airports, smaller cities) or become its supplier; show what each option is worth. |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **3 · TRUST** | **A safety incident under investigation** | A drone, aircraft or vehicle linked to your service is involved in an incident. No one is hurt, but the regulator opens an investigation and the video trends nationwide. Bookings fall 35%. | Cooperate fully, pause what is unsafe, publish findings and change procedures. Show how long recovery takes and what it costs. |
| **4 · MONEY** | **Jet fuel up 35%** | Jet fuel prices rise 35% in a month. Airlines, your customers or partners, cut spending on new projects by a quarter and delay paying your invoices by 60 days. | Protect cash: renegotiate terms, show airlines how you save them fuel or money, and cut costs. Show the runway. |

**Spare cards (replacements, rehearsals or a mid-round surprise)**

- Drone flights are banned in two cities after a near-miss
- Bird strikes ground a fleet for inspection
- A data breach exposes passengers' travel history
- A new airport opens and moves a key route away
- A pilots' and crew strike cancels 40% of flights for a week

## Round 3 · problem statements (at most 5 companies each)

1. Cut airport queue time from check-in to boarding by half
2. Make air travel fully accessible for passengers with disabilities
3. Turn aircraft around 20% faster without extra staff
4. Lost baggage found or delivered within 24 hours
5. Affordable flights to tier-3 towns with under 50 seats
6. Drone delivery of medicines to hilly and remote areas
7. Cut an airline's fuel use and carbon by 10% with data
8. Sustainable aviation fuel from Indian farm waste
9. One app for the whole door-to-door journey
10. Predict and prevent aircraft part failures before they ground a plane

## Finance track · what funds should watch

| Signal | Why |
|---|---|
| **Contract dependence** | Reliance on one airline or airport. |
| **Regulatory approvals** | Time and risk before revenue. |
| **Fuel sensitivity** | How the business behaves when fuel spikes. |
| **Safety record** | Incidents can stop operations. |
| **Capital before revenue** | Hardware and approvals cost cash early. |

# 7 · FINTECH: Financial services

Digital payments, app-based investing and online lending have reached hundreds of millions of people, but fraud, poor financial literacy, unfair credit and complex regulation remain. Fintech businesses live on trust and on the regulator's rules, so a breach, a market crash or a rule change moves them immediately, and Finance teams will know how to trade them.

## Broad problem statement (Round 1 · the problem card)

The financial services industry is undergoing a rapid digital transformation as consumers and businesses increasingly expect seamless payments, personalized financial solutions, instant access to credit, enhanced security, and greater financial transparency. However, millions of individuals and businesses continue to face challenges such as limited access to formal financial services, financial fraud, inefficient lending processes, low financial literacy, fragmented financial management, regulatory compliance complexities, and growing cybersecurity risks. At the same time, financial institutions struggle to leverage emerging technologies while maintaining customer trust, operational efficiency, and regulatory compliance. Design an innovative startup that addresses one or more of these interconnected challenges to help create a more accessible, secure, intelligent, and inclusive financial ecosystem while delivering measurable value to consumers, businesses, and financial institutions.

## Opportunity areas

### Access and credit

- Credit for people and shops without credit history
- Invoice and supply-chain finance
- Microinsurance

### Investing and wealth

- Robo-advice and ready-made portfolios
- Protecting first-time investors
- Quantitative and algorithmic tools used responsibly

### Security and compliance

- Fraud detection for UPI and cards
- Automated KYC and compliance
- Explainable, auditable AI

### Money management

- One view of all accounts
- Financial literacy that changes behaviour
- Saving and retirement for gig workers

## Real-world industry challenges

| Challenge | Why it matters |
|---|---|
| **Exclusion** | Many people and small businesses have no credit history, so banks will not lend to them. |
| **Fraud** | Every new payment method attracts new scams. |
| **Literacy** | New investors trade on tips and lose money in risky products. |
| **Regulation** | Rules change often, and compliance is costly for small firms. |
| **Trust and security** | One breach or bad algorithm can lose millions of users. |

## Startups for inspiration

- **Zerodha / smallcase (India)**: Low-cost investing and ready-made portfolios.
- **Groww (India)**: Simple investing for first-time investors.
- **Jupiter / Fi (India)**: App-first banking for young earners.

- **Lendingkart (India)**: Data-driven loans for small businesses.
- **Wealthfront (US)**: Robo-advice with automated rebalancing.

## Illustrative startup concept

**KHATAPLUS.** A cash-flow credit score for kirana shops built from their UPI receipts and supplier bills (with consent). Lenders use it to give small working-capital loans that the shop repays from daily sales.

**Revenue:** A fee per score for lenders; A share of interest on loans arranged; A premium bookkeeping app for shops.

## Product track · what a strong PRD shows

- The user (a person, a shop, a lender) and the money problem in rupees
- How the product makes money and what it costs to acquire a user
- Risk controls: defaults, fraud, model errors
- Regulatory fit: which rules apply and how the product complies
- Success metrics such as default rate, fraud caught, users retained or cost per loan

## Consulting track · Round 1 crisis memo (same case for every firm)

**Robo-portfolio crash.** A robo-advisor app with 4 lakh users promised 'low-risk' portfolios. A 12% market fall in a week cut its portfolios by 18%, more than the index. 30,000 users withdrew in three days and complaints reached the regulator.

Recommend one way out, with numbers: change the model, compensate users, explain and retain, or slow growth to rebuild trust. A strong memo is honest about what went wrong in the model.

## Round 2 · crisis cards

| Type | Card | What happens | A strong response |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 · OPERATIONS | **The algorithm misfires** | A bug in your model makes 6,000 wrong trades or loan decisions in one morning. Customers lose Rs 2.1 crore before you stop it. | Stop it, make customers whole, find the root cause and add controls (limits, human review, testing). Cost the compensation. |
| 2 · MARKET | **A market crash** | The market falls 14% in five days. Your users' portfolios (or your borrowers' sales) drop sharply, and 25% of users stop using the app. | Communicate early, help users avoid panic decisions, and protect the business from defaults or outflows. Show the runway. |
| 3 · TRUST | **A data breach** | Hackers leak the phone numbers and PAN details of 3 lakh users. Fraud calls start the same day and the news covers it. | Notify users and the regulator, contain the breach, protect users from fraud and fix security. Estimate the cost and the users at risk. |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **4 · MONEY** | **The regulator changes the rules** | The central bank tightens rules on your product: digital lending caps, new KYC checks, or limits on derivatives for small investors. Revenue from your main product falls 40%. | Comply first, then rebuild revenue from what the rules still allow. Show the new business model in numbers. |

**Spare cards (replacements, rehearsals or a mid-round surprise)**

- A partner bank ends its agreement with you at a month's notice
- A loan-default wave hits after a bad monsoon
- A deepfake video of your CEO promotes a scam
- UPI transaction charges are introduced
- A rival offers zero fees for a year

## Round 3 · problem statements (at most 5 companies each)

1. Stop first-time investors losing money in options
2. Fair credit for kirana shops with no credit history
3. Detect UPI fraud before the money leaves
4. Explain a portfolio's risk in one screen
5. Retirement saving for gig workers
6. Insurance claims settled in a day
7. Invoice finance for small exporters
8. Financial literacy that changes behaviour, not just knowledge
9. Credit scores from cash-flow data, with consent
10. Responsible AI that a regulator can audit

## Finance track · what funds should watch

| Signal | Why |
|---|---|
| **Regulatory risk** | A rule change can cut revenue overnight. |
| **Default and loss rates** | The core risk of lending. |
| **Retention after a shock** | Trust is the asset. |
| **Revenue concentration** | Dependence on one product or partner bank. |
| **Cost of compliance** | Cash needed just to stay legal. |

# 8 · LUXURY: Reengineering the next era of luxury

Luxury is moving beyond owning rare products towards personalised services, experiences, access and proof of authenticity. The sector's value rests on desirability and trust, so counterfeits, scandals, a generation's changing tastes or an economic downturn hit valuations hard. That makes luxury a natural test of brand judgement for Consulting firms and of conviction for Finance teams.

## Broad problem statement (Round 1 · the problem card)

The global luxury ecosystem is undergoing a fundamental transformation, moving beyond conventional paradigms of ownership, exclusivity and status towards hyper-personalisation, intelligent services and immersive experiences. Despite rapid market evolution, significant gaps persist in how luxury is conceptualised, delivered, accessed and sustained. From fragmented consumer journeys and underdeveloped experiential ecosystems to inefficient service infrastructure and evolving expectations of affluent consumers, the industry presents substantial opportunities for disruption. How might we leverage emerging business models, technological innovation and unconventional value propositions to architect the next generation of luxury products, services and experiences, transforming premium living into an entirely new market opportunity?

## Opportunity areas

### A · Experiences and hospitality

- Hyper-personalised luxury travel and hospitality
- Exclusive, curated experiences and private memberships
- Luxury concierge and lifestyle management platforms
- Immersive hospitality and destination-based experiences
- Personalised premium wellness and leisure services

### B · Intelligent luxury and personalisation

- AI-powered personal shopping assistants
- Predictive consumer preference platforms
- Bespoke product customisation and manufacturing
- Intelligent wardrobe and lifestyle management
- Personalised luxury recommendations and discovery

### C · Ownership and accessibility

- Alternative ownership and fractional luxury models
- Premium asset-sharing ecosystems
- Verified luxury resale and authentication platforms
- Subscription-based access to premium products
- Luxury rental and circular ownership models

### D · Infrastructure and services

- Smart luxury residences and intelligent living spaces
- Integrated property and lifestyle management
- Automated premium customer service infrastructure
- Exclusive mobility and transportation services
- Digital ecosystems connecting luxury service providers

### E · Sustainability and responsible luxury

- Sustainable luxury material innovation
- Product lifecycle and traceability solutions

### F · Brand innovation and engagement

- Next-generation luxury loyalty ecosystems
- Digital identity and authenticity verification
- Experiential brand engagement platforms

- Premium repair, restoration and refurbishment services
- Circular luxury commerce
- Ethical sourcing and supply-chain transparency
- New-age luxury communities and private networks
- Innovative brand extension and monetisation models

## Real-world industry challenges

| Challenge | Why it matters |
|---|---|
| **The exclusivity dilemma** | Expanding the customer base without diluting scarcity, prestige and brand equity. |
| **The personalisation gap** | Experiences are fragmented across stores, apps, hotels and personal services instead of one intelligent, personal ecosystem. |
| **The authenticity crisis** | Sophisticated counterfeits and a growing resale market undermine provenance and confidence. |
| **The ownership paradigm shift** | Access, flexibility, experiences and sharing challenge the model of owning products. |
| **The after-sales deficit** | Repair, warranty, maintenance and restoration are fragmented and inconsistent. |
| **The brand extension dilemma** | Moving into hospitality, wellness or real estate risks complexity and dilution. |
| **The sustainability paradox** | Premium, resource-heavy production must meet ethical sourcing and circular expectations. |

## Startups for inspiration

- **Aura Blockchain Consortium**: Digital certificates of authenticity and ownership for luxury goods.
- **Vestiaire Collective / The RealReal**: Authenticated luxury resale.
- **Rent the Runway**: Subscription and rental access to designer fashion.
- **Quintessentially**: Members-only lifestyle concierge.
- **Kapture-style clienteling tools**: Software that lets luxury stores know and serve each client personally.

## Illustrative startup concept

**LUXORA.** The operating system for luxury living: one digital ecosystem that connects affluent consumers with personalised lifestyle services, premium experiences, exclusive memberships, luxury property management, private travel and concierge services, and anticipates their preferences instead of making them deal with many separate providers. This is one interpretation; other teams could build luxury hardware, sustainable materials, premium hospitality, authentication technology or new ownership models.

**Revenue:** Premium annual memberships; Commission-based service partnerships; Exclusive brand collaborations; B2B partnerships with luxury hospitality and real estate companies; Personalised concierge subscriptions.

## Product track · what a strong PRD shows

- The client segment (new-money professionals, NRIs, the ultra-rich, aspirational buyers) and what they lack today
- Why it is luxury: scarcity, craft, service or access, not just a higher price
- How trust is earned: authentication, privacy, service quality
- Unit economics per member, item or experience
- Success metrics such as members retained, spend per client, resale value kept or authentication accuracy

## Consulting track · Round 1 crisis memo (same case for every firm)

**The exclusivity collapse.** A leading luxury house grew sales 40% in three years through mass-market collaborations, outlet stores and resale platforms. Its premium positioning is weakening: its top 5% of clients, who bring 45% of revenue, have cut spending by a third, and resale prices of its icons have fallen 25%.

Evaluate its long-term brand equity and recommend one strategy, with numbers: cut distribution to restore scarcity, launch a separate accessible line, or invest in top-client experiences. Say whether it remains a viable investment and why.

## Round 2 · crisis cards

| Type | Card | What happens | A strong response |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 · OPERATIONS | **The digital identity breach** | A premium lifestyle platform you depend on is breached: the purchase histories and private profiles of 40,000 high-net-worth clients leak. Several cancel their memberships and the press names your brand. | Protect clients first (notification, security, personal outreach), rebuild confidentiality and reduce dependence on the platform. Estimate the revenue at risk. |
| 2 · MARKET | **The experience economy disruption** | A disruptive startup offers ultra-personalised premium experiences without ownership. 20% of your clients shift spending to it within a quarter and engagement with your products falls. | Decide whether to partner, acquire, copy or differentiate; add experiences to your own offer where they fit the brand. Show the value of each option. |
| 3 · TRUST | **The counterfeit revolution** | Hyper-realistic counterfeits made with advanced manufacturing flood the market. Even experts cannot tell them apart; resale prices of authentic pieces fall 30% and returns from buyers who fear fakes rise 4×. | Prove authenticity (digital IDs, verified resale, guarantees), reassure clients and protect resale value. Cost the programme against the sales at risk. |
| 4 · MONEY | **The luxury market crash** | A sudden downturn cuts discretionary spending: luxury retail falls 18%, high-end hospitality bookings 25% and luxury real estate deals 30%. Your next funding round is postponed. | Protect cash without discounting the brand: focus on the most loyal clients, delay expansion, and find resilient revenue. Show the runway. |

### Spare cards (replacements, rehearsals or a mid-round surprise)

- The sustainability scandal: a report exposes unethical sourcing and excessive resource use across several high-end brands, including one of your suppliers
- The next-gen exodus: research shows younger affluent buyers moving to niche labels and independent creators; your under-35 sales fall 22%
- Mid-round surprise: a company that looked safe is itself put under investigation for counterfeit components
- An influencer you paid is exposed for fake reviews
- A 20% rise in import duty on luxury goods

> **The organisers' consulting structure on this platform.** The organisers' luxury brief proposes a consulting track in which firms analyse companies and make buy/sell decisions. On this platform that maps as follows: Round 1, the Exclusivity Collapse is the crisis memo every firm writes, and firms also make their BUY or SELL calls on the companies they follow. Round 2, the crisis cards above (the Counterfeit Revolution, the Experience Economy Disruption, the Digital Identity Breach and the Luxury Market Crash) arrive one by one; firms advise the companies that hire them and funds trade on each card. Round 3, the Next-Gen Exodus is a natural theme for the problem statements, and the mid-round surprise (a shortlisted company under investigation) can be published as a bulletin during any round.

## Round 3 · problem statements (at most 5 companies each)

1. Expand to new clients without losing exclusivity
2. One personal assistant for a client's whole luxury life
3. Prove any luxury item is genuine in seconds
4. Fractional ownership of art, cars or watches
5. After-sales care as good as the purchase
6. Turn a fashion brand into a hospitality experience
7. Luxury materials that are fully traceable and sustainable
8. Win the next generation of luxury buyers
9. Private, secure data for high-net-worth clients
10. Circular luxury: repair, resell and refurbish at scale

## Finance track · what funds should watch

| Signal | Why |
|---|---|
| **Brand equity** | Pricing power and resale value are the signals. |
| **Client concentration** | How much revenue the top clients bring. |
| **Authenticity exposure** | Risk from counterfeits and the resale market. |
| **Sensitivity to downturns** | Discretionary spending falls first. |
| **Reputation risk** | Scandals and breaches travel fast among wealthy clients. |

# Next steps

1. Confirm the sectors (the ranking suggests FMCG, Energy, Aviation and Fintech, with Luxury as a fifth).
2. Turn each pack into the platform's upload files: the problem cards (one per sector), the crisis deck (the four cards per sector plus spares) and the Round 3 statements.
3. Upload them on the organiser's Content page and run a rehearsal with a few teams per track.
4. Check every number on the cards before printing: they are invented for the game.